

Session 5: Jacob Tricks Esau

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew word *tam* means whole or complete and is used to describe people of moral integrity.
- Describing Yaaqov as a “smooth man” has a double meaning: This contrasts his appearance with that of his brother, but it also links his deceitful actions with a developing theme of tricksters and deceivers in the Bible.
- Yaaqov’s deception of Esau (Edom) replays the snake’s deception of Adam in the garden of Eden.

Yaaqov Tricks Esau the Firstborn

27 And the boys grew up,
and **Esau** was a man having knowledge of **hunted-game (ציד)**
a man of **the field**,
and **Yaaqov** was a man of wholeness (תם),
a dweller of tents.

28 And Yitskhaq **loved Esau**,
because **hunted-game (ציד)** was in his mouth,
and Rivqah **loved Yaaqov**.

29 And Yaaqov **stewed a stew (נייד)**,
and Esau came in from **the field**,
and **he was faint**;
30 **and Esau said** to Yaaqov,
“Please let me swallow that **red red**, for **I am faint**.”
Therefore his name was called **Edom / red (אדום)**

31 **And he said**,
“**Today**, **sell me your firstborn-right (בכרה)**.”
32 **And Esau said**,
“Look, I am going to die;
what is this (למה זה) to me, a **firstborn-right (בכרה)**?”
33 **And Yaaqov said**,
“**Today**, **swear an oath to me**,”
and **so he swore an oath to him**,
and **he sold his firstborn-right (בכרה)** to Yaaqov.
34 And Yaaqov gave to Esau bread and **stew (נייד)** of lentil beans;

and he ate and he drank
and he rose and he left,
and Esau despised his **firstborn-right** (בכרה).

Genesis 25:27-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Esau the Animal Slayer

Esau is introduced as a hunter (ציד ידע), a unique description that recalls an earlier generation of the non-chosen son: Ham, whose grandson was Nimrod, the founder of Babylon and Assyria.

Gen. 10:6 The sons of Ham; Cush ...

⁸ Now, Cush became the father of **Nimrod** ;
he began to be a **mighty warrior** in the land.

⁹ He was a **mighty warrior-hunter** (גבור ציד)
before Yahweh;
therefore it is said,
“Like Nimrod a mighty warrior-hunter
before Yahweh.”

¹⁰ And the beginning of his kingdom was **Babylon** and Erech and
Accad and Calneh, in the land of Shinar.

¹¹ From that land he went forth into **Assyria, and built Nineveh** ...

Gen. 25:27 Esau had **knowledge
of hunting game** (ידע ציד)

Gen. 25:30 Therefore his name is
called Edom

Esau/Edom becomes the father of
the **Edomites**

Esau the Animal Slayer. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Let's compare Esau with Ham and Nimrod.

- Ham and Esau are both the non-chosen sons.
- Esau and Nimrod are both animal slayers, a sign of being outside of Eden and at odds with the animals (see [Gen. 9:1-5](#)).
- Esau and Nimrod are both the founding figures of nations that will later become hostile to the family of Abraham: Babylon, Assyria, and Edom.
- Nimrod was a “violent warrior” (Heb. *gibbor* / גבור), a term used elsewhere of the Nephilim, the violent mutant offspring from the sons of *elohim* debacle in [Gen. 6:1-4](#). While Esau himself is never called a *gibbor*, he definitely acts like one! This sets up an analogy:
 - Nephilim/*gibborim* of the generation of the flood
 - Nimrod/*gibbor* of the generation of Babylon
 - Esau/*gibbor*-like of the generation of Yaaqov
 - Both the Nephilim and Nimrod are carried away in a flood of God’s judgment in the forms of cosmic-flood ([Gen. 6-8](#)) and the scattering of an empire ([Gen. 11](#)). This leads us to assume that Esau will also be associated with some coming form of divine judgment.

Yaaqov the “Whole Man”

Genesis 25:27 Instructor’s Translation

and **Esau**
was **a man knowing hunted-game (ציד)**
a man of the field,
and **Yaaqov**
was **a man of wholeness (תם),**
a dweller of tents

Notice the parallel contrast set up between Esau and Yaaqov. On one level, it seems like a simple contrast: Esau is an outdoorsman among the animals, while Yaaqov is more of a homebody.

The description of Yaaqov as “whole” is curious. When the word is used of people, it usually means “morally blameless, whole in moral character.”

Job 1:1 NASB

There was a man in the land of Uz whose name was Job; and that man was blameless (**תם האיש**), upright, fearing God and turning away from evil.

Psalms 37:37 NIV

Consider the blameless (**תם**), observe the upright; a future awaits those who seek peace.

Proverbs 29:10 NIV

The bloodthirsty hate the blameless (**תם**) and seek to kill the upright.

The above passages are clear that to be “whole” is to be a morally upright person. But this word describes Yaaqov in a story about how he cheats his brother!

This word is used in a purposefully ironic way to establish Yaaqov as an anti-Noah who doesn't trust God, but it also matches a description of Yaaqov in the next deception story in Genesis 27:11.

Genesis 6:9 NASB

Noah was a righteous man morally-whole (**תמים**) among his generation.

Genesis 25:27 NASB

Esau is a “man knowing hunted-game, **a man of the field (שדה איש) ...**”
Yaaqov is a **“man of wholeness (תם איש),** a dweller in the tents”

Genesis 27:11 NASB

Look Esau my brother is **a man of hair (איש שער)**
but I am **a man of smoothness (איש חלק)**.

These matching statements illuminate each other.

- Esau’s “outdoorsman” nature matches his “hairy” body
- Yaaqov's “wholeness” matches his “smooth” body

Not only that, but “smoothness” (**חלק**) is a word often used to describe smooth-talkers and deceptive people.

Psalm 12:2-3 NIV

² Everyone lies to their neighbor; they have **smooth lips** but harbor deception in their hearts.
³ May the LORD silence all **smooth lips** and every boastful tongue—

Proverbs 5:3 NIV

For the lips of the adulterous woman drip honey, and her speech is **smoother** than oil;

Proverbs 26:28 NIV

A lying tongue hates those it hurts, and a **mouth of smoothness** works ruin.

Conclusion: Yaaqov's “wholeness” is a deliberately ironic way to describe his smooth skin and his deceptive nature. It also marks him as anti-chosen, unlike Noah who actually was “morally whole” and marked for deliverance from the flood.

Stealing the Firstborn-Right

In this famous story, Yaaqov deceives his hungry, bumbling oaf of a brother. The story contains many vivid images that set up the tensions that will drive the rest of the Yaaqov story.

Plot Conflict Introduced	Plot Conflict Intensified	Plot Conflict Resolved
Gen. 25 Yaaqov deceives his brother Esau of his firstborn-right (<i>bekorah</i>).	Gen. 27 Yaaqov deceives his father and brother of the firstborn's blessing (<i>berakah</i>).	Not resolved until Genesis 33 and 37.
Yaaqov deceptively cheats to gain what God said was already his: the position of firstborn .	Yaaqov deceptively cheats to gain what God said would be his: the blessing .	Not resolved until Genesis 35.
<i>Stealing the Firstborn-Right</i> . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

The plot conflicts that begin in this story will generate the tension that spans the entire story of Yaaqov. This story introduces us to the big question at the heart of the Yaaqov story.

What if God's chosen one is so focused on self-gain and self-preservation that they constantly manipulate others to get what God already promised to give them and others through them?

In many ways, this develops the theme that began in the creation narratives: God wants to bless humans and all creation through them as they co-rule the world as God's partners.

But what if the humans don't trust God, so they take life and wisdom into their own hands in order to gain the very things God already said he would give them: abundance, security, status, authority, and blessing?

This explains why this little episode is riddled with language and themes from Genesis 1-3.

Genesis 1-4	Genesis 25-27
God creates “human” (Heb. <i>’adam</i> / אָדָם) and installs him with the authority of the firstborn over creation, including the animals.	The twins are born, and the name of the firstborn is “Edom” (<i>’edom</i> / אֶדֶם).
A non-chosen animal, the heel-striking snake, deceives <i>’adam</i> .	The chosen brother, the heel-grabbing Yaaqov, deceives <i>’edom</i> .
The deceived <i>’adam</i> takes and eats food that results in a loss of blessing and the onset of the curse.	The deceived <i>’edom</i> takes and eats food that results in the loss of his firstborn right and his blessing.
The non-chosen firstborn son, Cain, is a shepherd in the field, and is angered by God’s favor on his younger brother.	The non-chosen firstborn son, Esau, is a man of the field and angered by Yaaqov’s deception of his firstborn-right and blessing.
<i>Echoes of Genesis 1-4 in Genesis 25-27. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

Reflection Question

What do Yaaqov’s actions and the Bible’s description of him reveal about his attitude toward God’s promises?